

Clinical Dialogue Transcript — GAD

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Patient Model:	llama-3.1-8b-instant
Condition / DSM-5:	GAD
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Total Dialogue Turns:	21

THERAPIST (Turn 1)

Hi, thanks for coming in today. What's been going on for you lately?

PATIENT (Turn 2)

Honestly, everything and nothing? Like I'll be fine and then suddenly I'm thinking about whether I locked the car, or if my mom's flight is going to be okay, or some email I sent three days ago. It's just hard to keep track, you know?

THERAPIST (Turn 3)

I hear you. It sounds really exhausting—like your brain is constantly scanning for the next thing to worry about, jumping between the past (that email), the present (locking the car), and the future (your mom's flight). When your mind is switching gears like that, it makes complete sense that you feel like it's hard to keep track.

That "always-on" state can be really draining.

How long have you been feeling this kind of background noise of worry? And when it happens, how is it affecting your energy or your body lately?

PATIENT (Turn 4)

.. um, background noise... I guess that's a good way to put it. It's always been like this, to be honest. I don't know, a year or so now? But it's getting worse, I think. My shoulders are up by my ears half the day, and I just feel... tight. All the time.

THERAPIST (Turn 5)

A year is a really long time to carry that kind of physical tension around.

When your mind is constantly scanning for things to worry about, your body reacts as if there's an actual physical threat nearby—it stays braced for impact. Those shoulders creeping up toward your ears, that tight feeling... that's literally your body trying to protect you, but doing it on overdrive. It makes complete sense that you're feeling exhausted. Carrying that around every single day takes a massive physical toll.

Since you mentioned it feels like it's getting worse lately—do you feel like the weight of carrying this for a whole year is just starting to wear you down? Or has something specific shifted in your life recently that's cranked up the volume on that background noise?

PATIENT (Turn 6)

It's just... I don't know, I feel like I'm running on empty, you know? Like, I've just been trying to make it through each day without totally losing it. But sometimes I'll be sitting there, and I'll think to myself, "Is this normal?" Like, is it normal to feel like this all the time? And then I'll think about it and I'll be like, "No, it can't be normal." But at the same time, I don't know what's not normal.

THERAPIST (Turn 7)

It makes so much sense that you're questioning that. When you've been living in a state of high alert for so long, it starts to feel like "just how life is," even while your body and mind are screaming that it's too much. That conflict—feeling like this is just your default, but knowing deep down that it's wearing you out—is exhausting.

To answer your question directly: Is it *common* for people struggling with anxiety or chronic stress to feel this way? ****Yes, absolutely.**** You are definitely not alone in this, and feeling like you're running on empty doesn't mean you're "broken" or doing something wrong. Your nervous system has just been working overtime for way too long.

But is it how you *deserve* to live, or the only way your brain can operate? ****No.**** Living on empty and bracing for impact constantly isn't a baseline you have to just accept or endure.

When you say you're trying not to "totally lose it," what does "losing it" look like in your mind? What are you afraid might happen if you stop holding everything together so tightly?

PATIENT (Turn 8)

.. losing it... I don't know, just feeling like I'm completely falling apart, I guess. Like, my mind's a total mess, and I'm not even sure what's real anymore. I'd be worried that I'd forget everything, or that I'd say something stupid in front of people. Or that I'd just... break down in public. That's the worst part, I think.

THERAPIST (Turn 9)

It makes so much sense why you're holding on so tightly. The fear of "falling apart"—especially in front of other people—can feel absolutely terrifying.

When you've been running on empty for a long time, it feels like you're holding back a heavy door. You worry that if you relax your muscles or let your guard down for even a second, the door will fly open and everything will come crashing out—crying, losing control, making a scene, or totally unraveling. So you keep pushing against the door, even though your muscles are exhausted.

I want to gently reassure you about a couple of things that anxiety likes to twist:

First, **feeling like your mind is a mess or feeling disconnected isn't the same as actually losing touch with reality.** That fog and confusion happen when your brain is simply overwhelmed and overstimulated. It's a symptom of fatigue, not a sign that you are broken or losing your mind.

Second, anxiety convinces us that if we stop holding everything together, the outcome will be catastrophic. But usually, "falling apart" just looks like needing to cry, needing rest, or admitting to someone, "I'm having a really hard time right now."

Holding that door shut takes an incredible amount of energy, which is why your shoulders are up by your ears.

When you think about that fear of breaking down in public or losing control... has there ever been a moment recently where you felt like you actually **did** lose control, or is it mostly the constant, exhausting **threat** of it happening that keeps you bracing yourself?

PATIENT (Turn 10)

.. losing control... I don't know, it's more the threat of it, like you said. But there was this one time, not too long ago, when I was at work and I just... snapped. I started crying in front of everyone because I couldn't deal with this stupid presentation anymore. But it was like, 5 minutes of sobbing, and then I just stopped and walked out of there. It was so humiliating. And ever since then, I've been terrified of it happening again.

THERAPIST (Turn 11)

Thank you for being so brave in sharing that with me. I know it's not easy to talk about moments that bring up a lot of shame.

It makes complete sense now why you've been bracing yourself so tightly. You had a moment where the "door" actually gave way, and because it felt so painful and humiliating, your brain made a strict safety rule: *We can never, ever let that happen again.* So now, your body is staying on high alert 24/7 to protect you from another release like that.

I want to offer a slightly different perspective on what happened that day at work:

When a pressure cooker is on the stove for too long with no way to vent, eventually, the steam blows off. That five minutes of crying wasn't a sign that you are weak, broken, or "crazy." It was your body's natural emergency release valve. You had been carrying a year's worth of unaddressed tension, and your system simply hit its limit.

And even in that terrible moment... **you handled it.** You felt the overwhelm, your body cried for five minutes, you pulled yourself together, and you stepped away to get space. You survived your worst-case scenario.

When you look back on that presentation now, do you view it as a personal failure—like you did something wrong? Or can you start to see it as a human being who was just pushed way past their limit?

PATIENT (Turn 12)

.. I guess I never thought of it that way. I mean, it's still kind of embarrassing to think about, but... yeah, maybe I was just pushed too far. And I did survive it, didn't I? I mean, I walked out of there and took a few deep breaths and kept going. That's not nothing.

THERAPIST (Turn 13)

It is **definitely** not nothing. In fact, that's huge.

In what felt like your absolute worst moment—surrounded by people, totally overwhelmed—you didn't actually "lose control." You listened to your body, removed yourself from a toxic moment, took deep breaths, and brought yourself back to center. That's not a failure; that is incredible self-preservation and resilience.

You actually proved to yourself that day that even if the absolute worst happens, you are capable of getting yourself through it.

How does it feel right now, in this room, to look at that memory and give yourself a little bit of credit for surviving it, instead of just feeling ashamed of it? Does it change the pressure in your shoulders even just a tiny bit?

PATIENT (Turn 14)

It feels... a little bit lighter, I guess. Like, my shoulders aren't screaming at me as much right now. And yeah, it does feel kind of good to think about it like that – like I'm not completely broken, like I can handle things. I mean, it's a small step, but... yeah.

THERAPIST (Turn 15)

Small steps are everything. In fact, that shift you just made—from treating yourself with harsh judgment to treating yourself with a bit of understanding—is a really big deal.

Notice what just happened in your body, too. The moment you stopped beating yourself up for being human and gave yourself some grace, your shoulders relaxed. Your mind and body are directly connected like that. When you tell yourself "I am safe and I can handle this," your physical body gets the message and stops bracing so hard for impact.

You aren't broken. You're just a person whose nervous system has been running a marathon for a year without a rest stop.

As we finish up today, how would it feel to try taking just a tiny bit of that compassion with you this week? The next time you notice those shoulders creeping up toward your ears, or that background noise getting loud, what could you say to yourself in that moment?

PATIENT (Turn 16)

.. it feels like... maybe I can do this. Maybe I can take care of myself and not be so hard on myself all the time. I don't know, but it feels like a tiny bit of hope.

THERAPIST (Turn 17)

Hold onto that tiny bit of hope. Honestly, it's one of the most powerful places to start.

Unlearning a year's worth of harsh self-judgment and constant tension takes time—it's a practice, not a light switch. But today, you proved to yourself that you *are* capable of shifting your perspective and giving yourself permission to breathe.

This week, if the background noise gets loud again, see if you can gently catch yourself, drop those shoulders, and remind yourself: *"I am not broken. I can handle this, and I deserve to be gentle with myself."*

You did really brave, meaningful work today. How are you feeling overall as we wrap up for now?

PATIENT (Turn 18)

.. I'm feeling... lighter. And a little bit... hopeful, I guess. Like, maybe things can get better. And yeah, I can try being kinder to myself. It's a weird feeling, but it's kind of... nice.

THERAPIST (Turn 19)

That "weird" feeling is what it feels like when you finally give yourself permission to lay down a heavy weight you've been carrying for way too long. It *is* nice, and you completely earned it today.

You did a lot of heavy lifting in this session—shifting how you look at a painful memory and choosing to offer yourself kindness instead of criticism. That takes real effort.

Take that lighter feeling with you as you walk out the door today. Be gentle with yourself this week, notice when those shoulders start creeping up, and give yourself space to just breathe.

I'm really glad we got to talk today. Take good care of yourself, and we'll keep building on this hope next time.

PATIENT (Turn 20)

.. thanks. Yeah, I think I needed this. I'll try to remember to be kinder to myself, okay?

THERAPIST (Turn 21)

You're so welcome. I'm really glad you came in today and gave yourself this space—you genuinely deserved it.

Remember, you don't have to be perfect at it. Just taking it one day, or even one moment, at a time is enough.

Take care of yourself today, and I look forward to seeing you at our next session. Have a gentle rest of your week!